

REMEMBRANCE

THE MAGIC OF LATA*JI*

To the world, she was Lata Mangeshkar; for me, she was my inspiration, my motivation, my goddess. She has been my role model since the age of four, around the time I started listening to her on the radio and began singing myself. As a child, I thought she was a fairy who sings, until my mother told me that this beautiful voice belonged to a human being named Lata Mangeshkar. So, of course I wanted to meet her.

I was 10 years old when I fulfilled that dream. My parents had brought me to Bombay to kick off my career as a playback singer. I met her for the first time at the Film Centre in Tardeo through [composers] Kalyanji-Anandji. I remember she was recording '*Main Tujhse Milne Aayi*' (for the film *Heera*, 1973), a duet with Mohammed Rafi*ji*. I wanted to talk to her, ask her questions, but I was so awestruck that I just stood there with my mouth open and kept staring at her. There she was with her two long braids which ran all way to her feet. She smiled at my gobsmacked face, put a hand on my head and blessed me.

Lata Mangeshkar gave the songs she sang the beauty and form they needed. If someone were to ask me what perfection is, I would say it is Lata*ji*

She has given *ohda* (status) to playback singers and for that alone, she is bigger than anybody else. She symbolised how respected and treasured a playback singer can be. Yes, she sang beautifully-composed songs, but it was how she rendered them that made them as rich and evergreen as they are. A beautiful composition needs the correct projection and that is how it reaches the ears of the people and stays there. Lata*ji* gave the songs the beauty and form they needed. If someone were to ask me what perfection is, I would say it is Lata*ji*.

Over the years, I kept meeting her time and again and we developed a nice bond. It became a ritual to visit her house for Ganpati *darshan*. I was superstitious that if I don't go, something would go wrong. On one such visit, I complimented her scent and asked her the name of the perfume and she just handed me her Cartier bottle. I used it for a while but then the nozzle broke, so I couldn't use it. But I have the bottle still. It is an invaluable possession. I have also preserved a voice note she sent me.

Whenever I met her at her home in Peddar Road, she was very inquisitive. She wanted gossip—who is doing what, how is this person singing, why does this singer sing like that? She had a great sense of humour. With a straight face, she would crack a joke and leave you rolling with laughter. She would send me lots of songs on WhatsApp. We would exchange jokes too. She also had an elephant's memory. She even remembered the colour of the frock I wore on the day of our first meeting—green.

I last spoke to her on her birthday. She wasn't going out of the house or meeting anyone because of Covid. We had a nice, long conversation and I asked about her health. She said: "*Ek dum* fit. First class." At 91, her voice still had a childlike quality.

I have lived on her songs and as long as I live, I will be breathing in and feeding on her songs. Lata*ji ke baad koi hai hi nahin aur naa hoga* (there has never been anyone like her, nor will there ever be). Nobody can measure up to her. There's no comparison. I don't think any other actor or cricketer has had such a glorious career. She left us on the day of Saraswati Visarjan. For us, it turned out to be an actual Saraswati Visarjan. ■

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(As told to Suhani Singh)